(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

ADHD in adults

ADHD (attention deficit hyperactivity disorder) is a condition where the brain works differently to most people. If you have ADHD, you may have trouble with things like concentrating and sitting still. There are things you can do to help manage your symptoms.

ADHD in children and young people

There is separate information about ADHD in children and young people (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/adhd-children-teenagers/).

Symptoms of ADHD (attention deficit hyperactivity disorder)

Symptoms of ADHD involve your ability to pay attention to things (being inattentive), having high energy levels (being hyperactive) and your ability to control your impulses (being impulsive).

You may show signs of being inattentive, such as:

- being easily distracted or forgetful
- finding it hard to organise your time
- finding it hard to follow instructions or finish tasks
- losing things often, like your wallet, mobile or keys

You may show signs of being hyperactive and impulsive, including:

- having a lot of energy or feeling restless
- being very talkative or interrupting conversations
- making quick decisions without thinking about what might happen as a result

Most people with ADHD will have symptoms of both the inattentive and hyperactive-impulsive type. Some only show signs of one type.

These symptoms usually start before the age of 12.

ADHD is thought to be recognised less often in women than men. This may be because women with ADHD more commonly have inattentive symptoms and these can be harder to recognise than hyperactive symptoms.

Getting help with ADHD (attention deficit hyperactivity disorder)

If your ADHD symptoms are affecting your studies, work or relationships, make an appointment with a GP to find out what support is available.

At your appointment, the GP will ask about your symptoms and how they affect your life. They may also want to consider other conditions that could be causing your symptoms, such as autism, Tourette's or anxiety, to help you get the right care.

After the appointment, the GP may decide to refer you for an assessment with a mental health professional specialising in ADHD.

If you have already been diagnosed with ADHD in childhood and need help for your symptoms, talk to your GP about getting a referral.

People with ADHD may often have other conditions too, such as depression, anxiety or addictions, or a learning difficulty such as dyslexia.

What happens at an ADHD assessment

Your appointment will be with an ADHD specialist such as a psychiatrist.

They'll ask about the history of your symptoms, particularly if they started when you were a child, and how these symptoms affected you at school.

The assessment will focus on different areas of your life, including:

- work and education
- family and friends
- medical history, including any mental health issues

The specialist may want to contact someone who knows you well, such as a family member or close friend.

If you're diagnosed with ADHD, the specialist will talk to you about what this means and what will happen next, including what help and support may be available.

Waiting times for ADHD assessments

Waiting times vary and you may have to wait several months or years to access ADHD specialist services.

You may be able to find a clinic with shorter waiting lists through your GP using the Right to Choose scheme. Read about Right to Choose and your choices in the NHS (Link: www.nhs.uk/using-the-nhs/about-the-nhs/your-choices-in-the-nhs/).

You can ask for an NHS appointment at any clinic, including a private clinic, if it provides ADHD services for the NHS in England.

Find out more about diagnosis pathways for adults on the ADHD UK website (Link: https://adhduk.co.uk/diagnosis-pathways/).

How to manage ADHD (attention deficit hyperactivity disorder)

ADHD can be managed in many ways, including lifestyle changes, changes at work, or medicines.

It depends on your symptoms and how they're affecting you. Not everyone needs or wants to take medicine to help manage their ADHD symptoms.

When you get a diagnosis of ADHD, your specialist will discuss ways you can be supported.

Lifestyle

There are things you can do to help yourself.

Make time for physical activities you enjoy, as exercise has many health benefits (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/exercise/exercise-health-benefits/) and can be a good focus for your energy.

Exercise also helps reduce symptoms of anxiety and depression. Anxiety and depression can make your ADHD symptoms worse.

It's important to get enough sleep. Having a regular bedtime and a quiet dark bedroom can help. Try to avoid screens, caffeine, sugar and alcohol close to bedtime.

Aim for a healthy, balanced diet (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/eat-well/how-to-eat-a-balanced-diet/eating-a-balanced-diet/) and regular mealtimes.

You may also find it helpful to talk to friends and family about your ADHD.

Work, college or university

At your workplace or place of study, you can request changes to help you manage your ADHD. These are called "reasonable adjustments".

Reasonable adjustments may include things like:

- having a personalised work space in a quiet area
- having written instructions as well as spoken instructions
- having help from another person to plan and structure your tasks

You can read more about workplace adjustments and other ways to help ADHD on the ADHD UK website (Link: https://adhduk.co.uk/reasonable-adjustments/).

Medicines

ADHD medicines must be started and monitored by an ADHD specialist.

Medicines that can help with ADHD symptoms include methylphenidate (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/methylphenidate-adults/) or lisdexamfetamine.

You may need to try more than one medicine to find out what works for you.

A GP may be able to take over prescribing ADHD medicines, but only if there is a "shared care agreement" between the GP and the ADHD specialist. To find out more, talk to your ADHD specialist or GP.

Talking therapies

Talking therapies, such as cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/cognitive-behavioural-therapy-cbt/) or mindfulness (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/tips-and-support/mindfulness/), may be recommended for adults with ADHD.

ADHD and driving

You must tell the DVLA if your driving is affected by your ADHD or your ADHD medicine, or both.

Find out more about ADHD (attention deficit hyperactivity disorder) and driving on GOV.UK (Link: https://www.gov.uk/adhd-and-driving)

ADHD and mental health

People with ADHD may be more likely to have a mental health issues such as anxiety and depression.

They are also at higher risk of suicide.

If you're feeling like you want to end your life, it's important to tell someone.

Help and support is available right now if you need it. You do not have to struggle with difficult feelings alone.

Find out how to get help for suicidal thoughts (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/behaviours/help-for-suicidal-thoughts/).

What causes ADHD (attention deficit hyperactivity disorder)

The cause of ADHD is not always known. ADHD may be caused by genetic differences and often runs in families.

There are several other things linked to ADHD, including being born premature (before 37 weeks of pregnancy), having epilepsy, a brain injury and being autistic.

Some people with ADHD call themselves neurodivergent. Neurodiversity describes the range of different ways our brains work.

Help and support for ADHD (attention deficit hyperactivity disorder)

If you have ADHD, there are ways to help manage your condition in addition to support from your doctor and workplace.

There are ADHD support groups locally and online.

There are also a number of organisations and charities that can offer information and support about ADHD.

ADHD UK

Information and support for anyone affected by ADHD.

- Website: www.adhduk.co.uk (Link: https://adhduk.co.uk/)
- Adult ADHD self screening tool (ADHD UK) (Link: https://adhduk.co.uk/adult-adhd-screening-survey/)
- Support groups (ADHD UK) (Link: https://adhduk.co.uk/support/)

ADHD Adult UK

Information and peer support for adults with ADHD.

- Website: www.adhdadult.uk (Link: http://www.adhdadult.uk/)
- Resources (ADHD Adult UK) (Link: https://www.adhdadult.uk/resources/)

MindOUT

Mental health support for the LGBTQ community.

- Website: www.mindout.org.uk (Link: http://www.mindout.org.uk)
- Advice and information (MindOUT) (Link: https://mindout.org.uk/get-support/advice-and-information/)

Samaritans

Mental health support for everyone.

- Website: www.samaritans.org (Link: http://www.samaritans.org)
- How we can help (Samaritans) (Link: https://www.samaritans.org/how-we-can-help/)

Page last reviewed: 19 March 2025
Next review due: 19 March 2028